



long-term dominance is secure, he remains critical of certain structural decisions taken in recent years. His sharpest criticism was directed at the league's scheduling format, which he argues has diluted the commercial value promised to franchises at the time of purchase.

According to Modi, franchise agreements were based on a format in which every team would face each other twice, once at home and once away. When the IPL expanded to 10 teams in 2022, such a structure would have resulted in a 90-match league phase followed by four playoff fixtures. Instead, the tournament continues to operate with a 74-match format, meaning several teams do not play all opponents twice in a season.

"(For) every game, the BCCI gets 50 per cent, and the remaining 50 per cent is distributed to teams. So teams are now losing out on 20 games.

It is by contractual obligation for the fees that they're paying to provide them home and away," he said.

"The home and away is where the value is. If you don't have time in your calendar, don't increase the number of teams. Simple as that. That's not what we sold. Has everybody signed off on it? I guarantee not."

Modi argued that the absence of a full home-and-away structure has a direct financial impact on both franchises and the board, particularly in terms of media rights revenue, which remains the primary driver of IPL income.

"If there were 94 matches today on a home-and-away basis, Rs 118 crore a game, it's Rs 2,400 crore just from media rights. That's Rs 2,400 crore extra coming to the BCCI," he said.

"Out of this, Rs 1,200 crore would have gone to the 10 teams. Each

Star power: Before rivalries were built on runs and wickets, Lalit Modi sold the IPL's first night as a clash of personas: Shah Rukh Khan vs Vijay Mallya, not KKR vs RCB. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

team would have got Rs 120 crore, and the team value should automatically have been higher."

From a commercial standpoint, Modi believes increasing the number of matches would not dilute interest but rather enhance engagement by strengthening local rivalries and increasing inventory for broadcasters and advertisers.

Media rights still the primary growth engine

Since the IPL's inception in 2008, debates have continued over what truly fuels its commercial success. While fan engagement, merchandising and match-day experience are often highlighted as growth pillars, Modi believes media